

The Glorious King of Tantras on the Intention of Wisdom

Śrī Jñānāśaya Tantra Rāja · Toh 404 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་ཡེ་ཤེས་བསམ་པའི་རྒྱལ་པོ་

Toh 404 in the Kangyur is a tantric scripture known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Jñānāśaya Tantra Rāja and in Tibetan as Dpal ye shes bsam pa'i rgyud kyi rgyal po, rendered in English as The Glorious King of Tantras on the Intention of Wisdom. It belongs to the class of Buddhist tantric texts and concerns the nature, varieties, and sovereign power of wisdom, explored through a dialogue in which the Hero Wisdom-Ḍākinī petitions the Blessed One — identified with the glorious Vajrasattva — to explain the intrinsic character of wisdom and those who embody or are tamed by it. The teaching unfolds in verse within an assembly of innumerable heroes and ḍākinīs gathered at a secret place of wisdom, placing this text firmly within the esoteric Vajrayāna tradition of the Kangyur.

In the language of India: Śrī Jñānāśaya Tantra Rāja. In the language of Tibet: The Glorious King of Tantras on the Intention of Wisdom.

Homage to the Glorious Vajrasattva.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling together with a retinue of innumerable heroes (vīras) and ḍākinīs at the secret place of wisdom. At that time, the one called the Hero Wisdom-Ḍākinī touched the crown of her head to the feet of the Blessed One, joined her palms together, and made this request:

O Blessed One, great lord of wisdom,
The intrinsic nature of wisdom itself,
The various birthplaces of wisdom,
How it is that wisdom is the king,
Over whom it holds sway, by whom it is tamed —
All of this I pray you to explain to me.

The Blessed One declared:

Hearken, Hero Wisdom-Ḍākinī.
What is called wisdom has five aspects.
Because it knows the reality of suchness,
And is not obscured by erroneous conceptual thought,

The first is called the wisdom of the crown.
Mirror-like wisdom, wisdom of equality,
Discriminating wisdom and all-accomplishing —
The fifth is the wisdom of the dharmadhātu.

Now, mirror-like wisdom is like this:
Just as a reflection appears clearly
In a clean and flawless mirror,
So likewise, in the mirror of the mind,
Once the rust of afflictions has been cleansed,
All phenomena appear as illusory reflections.
That mirror of the mind, in which
All appearances are nothing but illusion —
Not dividing them as separate, the wisdom of equality.

What is the wisdom of equality:
Those conventional appearances, mere illusion,
With their functions and defining marks unmixed —
That itself is discriminating wisdom.
That same wisdom is the agent of accomplishment,
That same wisdom is all-accomplishing wisdom.
All things are nothing other than the dharmadhātu,
Therefore it is the wisdom of the dharmadhātu.

As for the birthplaces of wisdom,
They are the eight channels at the central junction.
The manner of dharmadhātu and wisdom being non-dual,
East and south and west and north —
These are the birthplaces of the four wisdoms.
The navel, where all of these converge,
Is the birthplace of the wisdom of the dharmadhātu.

Mirror-like wisdom, the wisdom of equality,
Discriminating wisdom and all-accomplishing,
The wisdom of the dharmadhātu and so forth —
Because they are the agents of sovereignty,
And because they vanquish all afflictions
Such as aversion, pride,
Attachment, jealousy,

And delusion and the rest,
This is why it is taught as the king.

The Wisdom-Ḍākinī then asked again:

What is the nature of the awakening mind (bodhicitta)?
What are its divisions?
What is its place of abiding, and the place of its apprehension?
The manner of its definitive reversal,
Its fruit, its signs, and its qualities —
All of this I pray you to explain to me.

The Blessed One declared:

The awakening mind is self-aware cognition.
In meaning, its divisions are taught as two.
Its place of abiding is in the channels,
And its apprehension is in the wheel of awareness.
The means of definitive reversal
Is the method of reversing direction.
Its fruit is the realization of non-duality.
Its signs are: blood arising in the body,
Hairs standing on end, trembling,
Little appetite, lightness of body,
Whitening hair and wrinkles loosening,
Freedom from laziness, and being endowed with diligence —
These and similar signs come to be accomplished.

Then the qualities are explained:
Swift of foot, on the surface of the earth and below it,
Whatever worldly siddhis (Skt. siddhi) there are,
And what transcends the world — these will be attained.
The abode of the non-dual awakening mind
Is self-aware luminosity, that very suchness.
The abiding nature is the intrinsic nature of wisdom,
And its sign is that very luminosity.
Its fruit is the certain attainment of the ground
That is the great bearer of the dharmakāya.

Examine the meditation in which the yogi holds mind:
Having harnessed body and mind together,

On the suchness of one's own mind
Meditate inseparably from that suchness.
By this one attains the fruit that is beyond attainment.

Thus did the Blessed One speak.

The entire retinue of wisdom *ḍākinīs* and all the others rejoiced in what had been said, offered the unsurpassed worship of suchness itself, and then vanished from sight.

The Glorious Cakrasaṃvara: King of Tantras of the Wisdom Intention is complete.

Translated by the paṇḍita Gayadhara and the monk-translator Śākya Yeshe.

Translator's Notes

- The text identifies five wisdoms but names only four in the enumeration verse before adding the dharmadhātu wisdom as the fifth. The passage then describes mirror-like wisdom, wisdom of equality, discriminating wisdom, all-accomplishing wisdom, and dharmadhātu wisdom, which are the standard Vajrayāna five wisdoms (*pañcajñāna*). The rendering "wisdom of the crown" for the first type follows the verse structure; some editions read this differently, and it may refer to a preliminary or encompassing category rather than a distinct sixth wisdom.

The phrase "eight channels at the central junction" refers to the tantric subtle-body physiology; "central junction" renders "kha sbyor dbus," literally "the center of the junction/confluence."

The line on "reversing direction" (*go bzlog pa*) refers to the tantric practice of reversing the downward movement of the awakening mind within the channels.

- The closing phrase "offered the unsurpassed worship of suchness itself" renders the idiom of offering the highest veneration by resting in recognition of reality as it is, a standard tantric colophon gesture. The phrase "vanished from sight" translates the conventional dissolution formula indicating the assembly dispersed or the vision dissolved, standard at the close of a tantra.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.